Planning a workshop: guide and checklist

Why a joint workshop?

Using Git also means deciding how editorial work is organised, checked and preserved. These decisions affect the whole project. We therefore recommend a joint workshop for every editorial team considering Git or already committed to using it. Starting with Git without developing a strategy is not a good foundation.

Responsibility

IT specialists can explain technical possibilities and implement solutions. The editorial team must take responsibility for scholarly and organisational decisions. A single Git expert should not carry that responsibility alone either. Everyone should understand the basic workflow and its consequences and contribute to the agreements. They do not all need to master the same technical tasks.

What we can gain

The workshop is also an opportunity to discover possibilities and improve established methods: what supports our research? How do we check changes? How do we want to collaborate? A practical introduction using your own texts often helps more than an abstract technical demonstration.

Outcome

The outcome is an initial jointly agreed Git strategy, explicit open questions, responsible roles and next practical checks. Scholarly responsibility is shared; technical tasks can be distributed. The workshop is tailored to your project.

Preparation

1. Prepare a small, understandable sample of your edition data and a concrete working question.
2. Collect existing rules, service commitments and difficulties; check confidential material before a demonstration.
3. Send the purpose, guiding questions and selected resources to participants beforehand.
4. Arrange a shared screen or printouts. Individual accounts and installations are only needed if a practical exercise has been explicitly prepared.

Editable agenda

1. **Agree the purpose and goal**: Which decision do we need today? Which open questions define the workshop's scope?
2. **Develop a shared understanding**: Demonstrate with a text file: compare, record, transfer and retrieve a change. Distinguish Git from hosting.
3. **Explore your project**: Relate the relevant project case and selected materials to our tasks. Examine possibilities and consequences together.
4. **Break**: Time to pause and ask informal questions.
5. **Draft agreements**: Record rules, data responsibility, roles and next checks. Assign a clarification task to each open question.

6. **Record results and next steps**: What have we agreed? Who will test what, and by when? When will we review our strategy?

Who should be involved?

- **Editorial team and project leadership**: Agree goals, rules and responsibility together. Include different tasks and levels of experience.
- **A colleague / scholarly adviser**: An individual project benefits from questions by someone who can understand the text and workflow.
- **Facilitation and notes**: Support discussion and timing; distinguish decisions, disagreements and open questions. These roles can be shared within the team.
- **Technical partners / infrastructure staff**: Explain actual possibilities, setup, interfaces and operation. The team defines and takes responsibility for scholarly requirements.
- **Library / research data management / archive service**: Discuss releases, citation, deposit and preservation in relation to the actual service offered.
- **Publisher / publication partner / typesetting service**: Join the session on outputs, handovers, rights and schedules. Internal team matters need a separate setting.
- **Potential users, for example from a seminar**: Try whether data and instructions are understandable and usable locally outside the team.
- **Relevant privacy adviser / staff representation**: For identifiable working histories or process analysis, clarify purpose, access and permitted scope in advance. Identify the appropriate institutional contact.
- **Staff responsible for hosting, backups and support**: Ask for the scope, limits, responsibility and duration in writing. A possible installation is not a service commitment.

Decision record

Decision | Reason | open / agreed / checked | Responsible role | Next test | Date … | … | … | … | … | …

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